JPEG-LS ENCODER IP CORE · V1.3

# OpenJLS

Lossless JPEG-LS encoder for FPGAs.
One pixel per clock, no external memory.

| 280 MHz | 1 px/clk | 8–16 bit | 5639/5639 |
|---|---|---|---|
| FMAX, 12-BIT | THROUGHPUT | PIXEL DEPTH | BYTE-EXACT ON SILICON |

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# Overview

OpenJLS is a lossless JPEG-LS encoder IP core for FPGAs. It takes one grayscale pixel per clock over a ready/valid stream and emits a standard JPEG-LS bitstream, buffering a single image row on-chip. It is portable VHDL, verified byte-exact against the CharLS reference in simulation and on silicon.

Source and verification suite: `https://github.com/isentropic-fpga/OpenJLS`
Demo projects: `https://github.com/isentropic-fpga/OpenJLS-Demos`

**Table 1** Key specifications.

| | |
|---|---|
| **Standard** | JPEG-LS[1] |
| **Compression** | Lossless |
| **Components** | Grayscale |
| **Pixel depth** | 8–16 bit[2] |
| **Image size** | Up to 65535 × 65535 px |
| **Throughput** | 1 pixel / clock |
| **Latency** | 14 cycles |
| **$f_{max}$** | ≈280 MHz[3] |
| **Interface** | Ready/valid stream[4] |
| **Memory** | On-chip only[5] |
| **Resources** | 5.3–7.6k LUT, 1.8–2.3k FF[6] |
| **Portability** | Vendor-agnostic VHDL |

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# Functional description

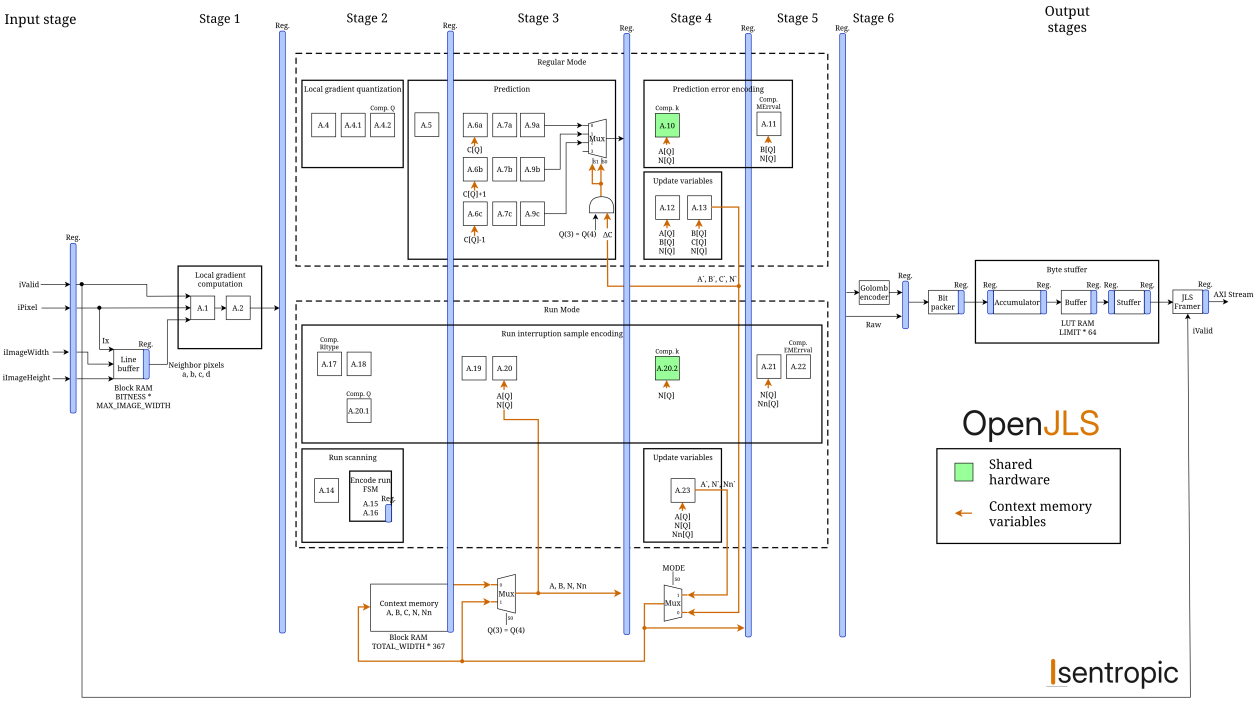
The core is a fully pipelined encoder with a latency of 14 clock cycles: an input register, six processing stages (gradient computation, context modeling, MED prediction with bias correction, Golomb–Rice / run-length coding) and seven internally registered output stages (bit packer, byte stuffer, framer). The architecture builds on Mert [2]; RAM primitives come from open-logic [4].

End-of-image is derived internally from the dimensions provided at the ports `iImageWidth` and `iImageHeight`. The core never stalls at end of line or end of image, so images stream back-to-back. It stalls only when downstream backpressure fills the byte-stuffer buffer. In principle the byte stuffer's fixed 4-byte-per-clock drain could also stall the input if the code rate exceeded it for long enough, but none of the random, adversarial or worst-case natural images we measured caused a stall.

The output stages assert `oValid` only once a full `OUT_WIDTH` word is ready, so output beats are much rarer than input pixels.

[1] ISO/IEC 14495-1, ITU-T T.87.
[2] Set by the `BITNESS` generic.
[3] 12-bit, Xilinx `xczu7eg-1`.
[4] AXI4-Stream and Avalon-ST compatible.
[5] One image row; no external RAM.
[6] Across 8–16 bit, plus block RAM that scales with image width and pixel depth.

**Figure 1** Encoder pipeline architecture.




A full-resolution version of this diagram is available in the repository.

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# Generics

**Table 2** Configuration generics.

| GENERIC | RANGE | DESCRIPTION |
|---|---|---|
| `BITNESS` | 8–16 | Pixel bit depth. |
| `MAX_IMAGE_WIDTH` | 4–65535 | Largest width supported; sets line-buffer depth. |
| `MAX_IMAGE_HEIGHT` | 1–65535 | Largest height supported. |
| `OUT_WIDTH` | 48–1024 | Output bus width in bits; multiple of 8. |

`MAX_IMAGE_WIDTH` and `MAX_IMAGE_HEIGHT` set the *compile-time* maximum and size the line buffer and dimension counters. Each image's actual size is set at *run time* through `iImageWidth` and `iImageHeight` (Table 3), up to that maximum.

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# Ports

All ports are synchronous to the rising edge of `iClk` — the core is a single clock domain. The streaming ports use a plain ready/valid handshake; in Table 3 the **AXIS** column gives the one-to-one AXI4-Stream signal mapping for that ecosystem (Avalon-ST maps the same way at `readyLatency` = 0).

**Table 3** Port list and AXI4-Stream mapping.

| PORT | DIR | WIDTH | AXIS | ROLE |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| iClk | in | 1 | — | Clock. |
| iRst | in | 1 | — | Synchronous reset, active high; latches dimensions. |
| iImageWidth | in | 16 | — | Image width, pixels (configuration). |
| iImageHeight | in | 16 | — | Image height, pixels (configuration). |
| iValid | in | 1 | TVALID | Pixel valid. |
| iPixel | in | BITNESS | TDATA | Pixel data. |
| oReady | out | 1 | TREADY | Input ready. |
| oData | out | OUT_WIDTH | TDATA | Bitstream beat. |
| oValid | out | 1 | TVALID | Output valid. |
| oKeep | out | OUT_WIDTH/8 | TKEEP | Valid-byte mask on final beat. |
| oLast | out | 1 | TLAST | End of image. |
| iReady | in | 1 | TREADY | Downstream ready. |

*IMPORTANT:*

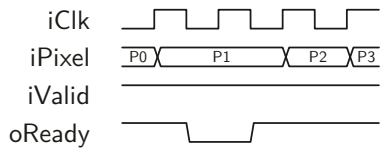
- iImageWidth and iImageHeight are only sampled while iRst is asserted ('1').
- Out-of-range values (width outside 4–MAX_IMAGE_WIDTH, height outside 1–MAX_IMAGE_HEIGHT) fall back to the maximum.
- If you don't intend to change the image dimensions at run-time, wire both inputs to 0 so that the maximum values are used.
- Both ports are a fixed 16 bits regardless of the MAX_IMAGE_* generics, which keeps them usable in Vivado block designs (their port-width evaluator handles only literal arithmetic).

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# Timing and protocol

**Pixel input.** Pixels are streamed in scan order — the first row left to right, then the second row, and so on — each an unsigned value on iPixel. A pixel transfers on every cycle where iValid and oReady are both high. Outside reset, the core holds oReady high and drops it only when the byte-stuffer buffer fills under downstream back-pressure. Figure 2 shows a transfer with a brief downstream stall.

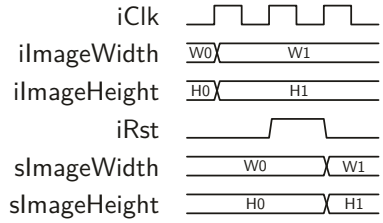
**Figure 2** Pixel-input handshake.




No pixel is dropped while oReady is low.

**Reset and configuration.** iRst is level-sensitive (hold it high for at least one clock) and clears the pipeline. The image dimensions are captured only while iRst is high: present iImageWidth and iImageHeight, hold them stable across the reset pulse, and they latch on the rising edge (Figure 3). A reset is therefore needed only to capture the dimensions — before the first image and whenever the image size changes; with the size unchanged, images encode back-to-back.

**Figure 3** Reset and dimension capture.




`sImageWidth` and `sImageHeight` are the internal registers that hold the dimensions; they load on the rising edge while `iRst` is high.

**Output.** Beats appear on `oData`/`oValid` subject to `iReady`; `oLast` marks the final beat (EOI) and `oKeep` flags its valid bytes. The bitstream is byte-serial and MSB-first: the earliest byte occupies the most-significant byte of `oData`.

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# Resources and performance

Characterized on Xilinx Zynq UltraScale+ `xczu7eg-fbvb900-1-e`, Vivado 2025.2, with `OUT_WIDTH = 64`, RTL-only with no floorplanning. $f_{max}$ is the true maximum, found by over-constraining the clock until timing fails. At one pixel per clock, ≈280 MHz is ≈280 Mpixel/s.

Every configuration is implemented with four strategies: the Vivado default, EPRPO (`Performance_ExplorePostRoutePhysOpt`), NetDelay (`Performance_NetDelay_high`) and Congestion (`Congestion_SpreadLogic_high`). Frequencies are in MHz; bold marks the best strategy per row. Resources are for the default strategy and near-identical across strategies.

## Image width sweep

`BITNESS = 12`, `MAX_IMAGE_WIDTH` from 4096 to 65535. The design is congestion-bound, so the winning strategy shifts with image size and with netlist changes; the best-of band (≈282–289 MHz) is the headline figure. Strategies differ by 7–22 MHz per size, so a default run lands close to it. Logic is essentially constant with image size; only the line-buffer BRAM scales with width.

**Figure 4** Maximum frequency vs maximum image width.

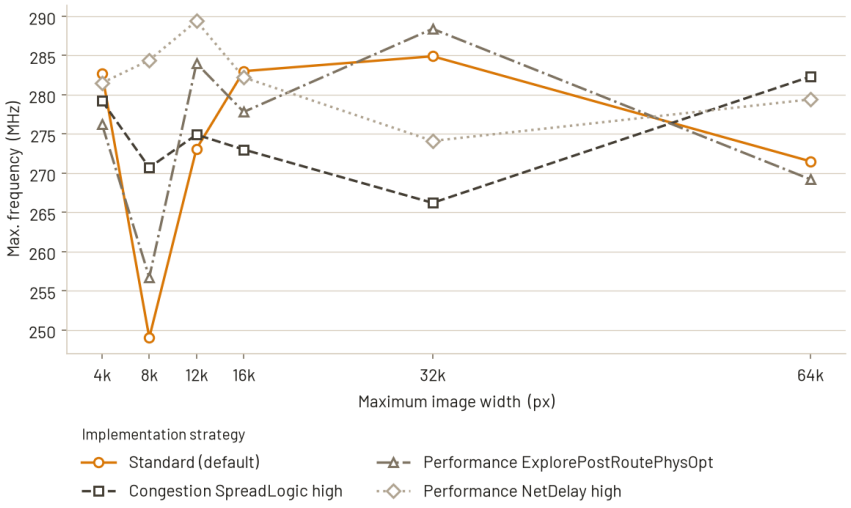


**Table 4** Maximum frequency by maximum image width and strategy.

| MAX_IMAGE_WIDTH | DEFAULT | EPRPO | NETDELAY | CONGESTION |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 4096 | **282.7** | 276.2 | 281.5 | 279.2 |
| 8192 | 249.0 | 256.7 | **284.4** | 270.7 |
| 12288 | 273.1 | 284.0 | **289.4** | 274.9 |
| 16384 | **283.0** | 277.8 | 282.2 | 273.0 |
| 32768 | 284.9 | **288.4** | 274.1 | 266.2 |
| 65535 | 271.5 | 269.2 | 279.4 | **282.3** |

**Figure 5** Resource usage vs maximum image width.

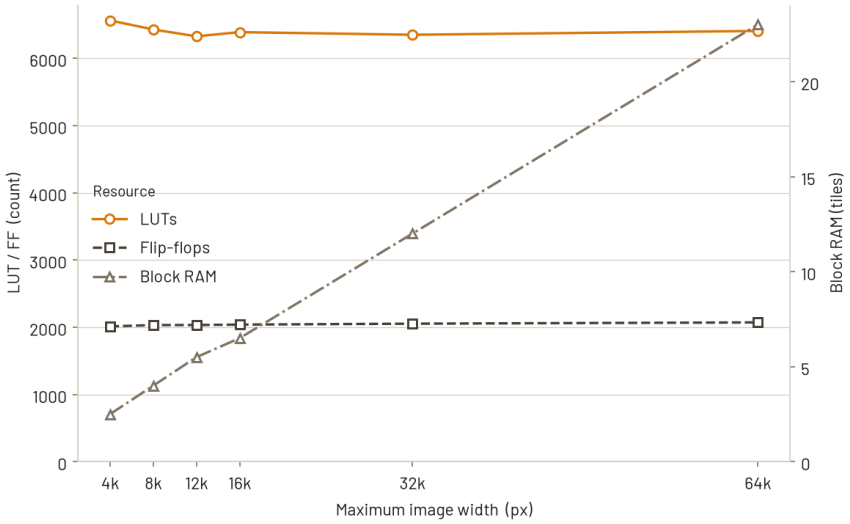



**Table 5** Resource usage by maximum image width.

| MAX_IMAGE_WIDTH | LUT | FF | BRAM |
|---|---|---|---|
| 4096 | 6563 | 2013 | 2.5 |
| 8192 | 6429 | 2032 | 4.0 |
| 12288 | 6327 | 2033 | 5.5 |
| 16384 | 6389 | 2039 | 6.5 |
| 32768 | 6350 | 2053 | 12.0 |
| 65535 | 6407 | 2072 | 23.0 |

## Pixel depth sweep

`MAX_IMAGE_WIDTH = 12288`, `BITNESS` from 8 to 16. Best-of $f_{max}$ falls from ≈305 MHz at 8 bits to ≈277 MHz at 14 bits and ≈225 MHz at 16 bits. The byte stuffer is off the critical path at every depth; the limit is the context RAM read into the prediction-error register, whose carry chains widen with pixel depth. Logic and line-buffer BRAM both grow with depth.

**Figure 6** Maximum frequency vs pixel bit depth (`MAX_IMAGE_WIDTH = 12288`).

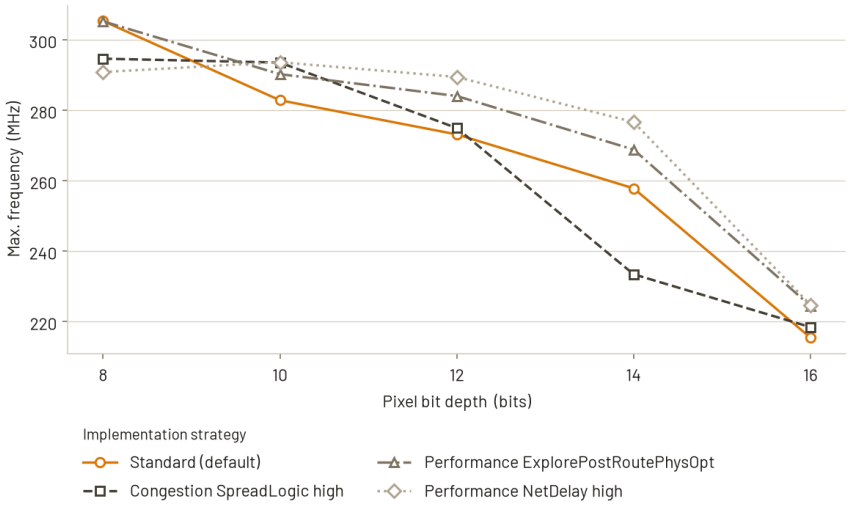



**Table 6** Maximum frequency by pixel bit depth and strategy (`MAX_IMAGE_WIDTH = 12288`).

| BITNESS | DEFAULT | EPRPO | NETDELAY | CONGESTION |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 8 | **305.3** | 305.2 | 290.8 | 294.6 |
| 10 | 282.8 | 290.2 | **293.6** | 293.5 |
| 12 | 273.1 | 284.0 | **289.4** | 274.9 |
| 14 | 257.8 | 268.8 | **276.6** | 233.4 |
| 16 | 215.4 | 224.4 | **224.7** | 218.4 |

**Figure 7** Resource usage vs pixel bit depth (`MAX_IMAGE_WIDTH = 12288`).

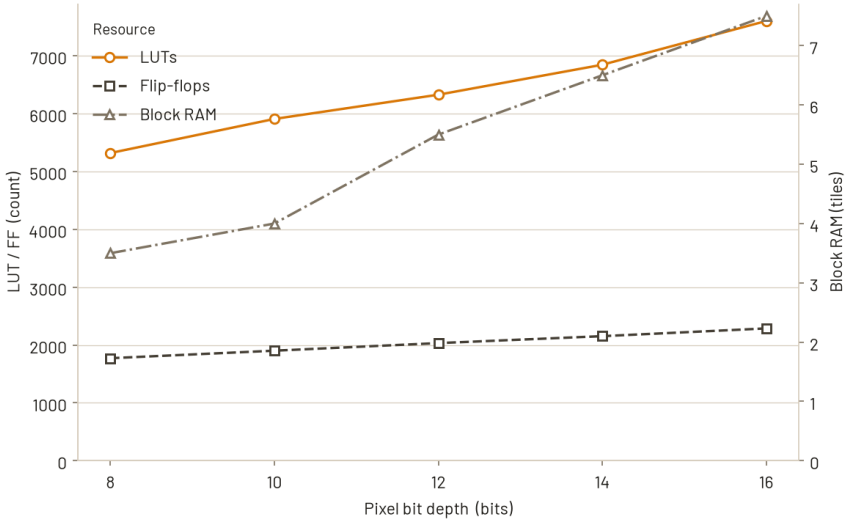


**Table 7** Resource usage by pixel bit depth (`MAX_IMAGE_WIDTH = 12288`).

| BITNESS | LUT | FF | BRAM |
|---|---|---|---|
| 8 | 5319 | 1772 | 3.5 |
| 10 | 5908 | 1902 | 4.0 |
| 12 | 6327 | 2033 | 5.5 |
| 14 | 6845 | 2153 | 6.5 |
| 16 | 7601 | 2287 | 7.5 |

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# Integration example

```
u_enc : entity work.openjls_top
  generic map (
    BITNESS => 8,
    MAX_IMAGE_WIDTH => 4096,
    MAX_IMAGE_HEIGHT => 4096,
    OUT_WIDTH => 64 )
  port map (
    iClk => clk,
    iRst => rst,
    iImageWidth => img_w, -- latched on reset
    iImageHeight => img_h, -- latched on reset
    iValid => s_valid, -- pixel stream (AXIS slave)
    iPixel => s_data,
    oReady => s_ready,
    oData => m_tdata, -- bitstream (AXIS master)
    oValid => m_tvalid,
    oKeep => m_tkeep,
    oLast => m_tlast,
    iReady => m_tready );
```

It can also be added to a block design as an RTL module.

## Xilinx IP cores

For the Vivado flow the core ships the following pre-packaged IPs:

| IP CATALOG NAME | INTERFACES |
|---|---|
| OpenJLS Encoder (Native) | Plain ready/valid |
| OpenJLS Encoder (AXI4-Stream) | AXI-Stream for the data, native pins for control |
| OpenJLS Encoder (AXI4-Stream + AXI4-Lite) | AXI-Stream for the data, AXI-Lite for control |

Add `Sources/Xilinx/ip_repo/` to the project's IP repositories and the three cores appear in the IP Catalog, ready to drop onto a block design.

## AXI4-Lite register map

The AXI4-Lite variant replaces the native control pins with a register bank (32-bit registers, word-aligned offsets):

| OFFSET | NAME | ACCESS | CONTENTS |
|---|---|---|---|
| 0x00 | ID | RO | ASCII "OJLS" (0x4F4A4C53) |
| 0x04 | VERSION | RO | 0x00MMmmpp (major/minor/patch) |
| 0x08 | CAPS | RO | [7:0] BITNESS, [15:8] output bytes per beat (OUT_WIDTH/8) |
| 0x0C | MAXDIM | RO | [15:0] MAX_IMAGE_WIDTH, [31:16] MAX_IMAGE_HEIGHT |
| 0x10 | WIDTH | RW | [15:0] image width (clamped on write) |
| 0x14 | HEIGHT | RW | [15:0] image height (clamped on write) |
| 0x18 | CTRL | WO | [0] APPLY — self-clearing, pulses the core reset |
| 0x1C | STATUS | RO | [0] BUSY (reset pulse active), [1] pixel-stream TREADY mirror |

The core samples the dimensions only while its reset is high, so reconfiguration is: write WIDTH/HEIGHT, set CTRL.APPLY. APPLY pulses the core reset for one clock while the registers are held stable; the AXI-Lite endpoint itself stays on aresetn only, so the bus never disappears mid-reconfigure. While the pulse is active STATUS.BUSY reads 1 and the pixel stream's TREADY is held low, so a stream started too early stalls instead of losing pixels — WIDTH/HEIGHT/CTRL writes while BUSY are dropped. **APPLY aborts any image in flight — only apply between images.** Back-to-back images of unchanged dimensions need no APPLY.

WIDTH/HEIGHT writes are merged per WSTRB and clamped to the core's rule (out-of-range values become the MAX generic), so a readback always returns the value the core will actually use. Writes to RO or unmapped offsets are acknowledged (OKAY) and dropped; unmapped reads return zero.

For driver code there is a C header in the repository, ojls_regs.h.

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# Conformance and verification

Verified by simulation with NVC using a layered, self-checking suite run at both RTL and post-synthesis (gate-level) stages:

- **OSVVM** — Per-module tests against independent T.87-derived reference models, top-level control-plane stress (reset injection, backpressure, back-to-back images, dimension fallback), and AXI wrapper tests (byte-exact AXI4-Stream pass-through at 8- and 12-bit, AXI4-Lite register map, live reconfiguration, mid-image abort), all with requirements tracking.
- **Coverage** — OSVVM functional coverage with NVC structural code coverage.
- **Golden model** — Byte-exact vs CharLS on all 5555 simulation-size images (up to 0.5 MP, 8–16 bit) plus the ISO/IEC 14495-1 vectors.
- **Design contracts** — Embedded PSL assertions (ready/valid handshake protocol, internal handshakes) on every run.
- **Post-synthesis** — The stress test and a golden-model subset re-run on the synthesized netlist.
- **Hardware-in-the-loop** — The golden-model comparison on silicon: the full 5639-image corpus, including the 84 full-size originals, encoded on a PYNQ-Z2 FPGA and byte-compared against CharLS. Run by the EncodeOverEthernet project in OpenJLS-Demos.

The golden corpus (Table 8) combines natural photographs (USC-SIPI, imagecompression.info), which exist only at 8 and 16 bits, with natural-derived crops of the 16-bit photographs rescaled to each depth 9–16, seeded white and $1/f^{\beta}$ noise probes, and boundary/adversarial stress probes. Images over 0.5 MP are sliced into full-width strips for simulation; their 84 full-size originals are part of the corpus but run on hardware only.

**Table 8** Golden-model corpus per bit depth.

| BITS | NATURAL | NATURAL DERIVED | NOISE | STRESS | FULL-SIZE | TOTAL |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 8 | 363 | 0 | 300 | 0 | 69 | 732 |
| 9 | 0 | 300 | 300 | 2 | 0 | 602 |
| 10 | 0 | 301 | 300 | 2 | 0 | 603 |
| 11 | 0 | 300 | 300 | 2 | 0 | 602 |
| 12 | 0 | 300 | 300 | 2 | 0 | 602 |
| 13 | 0 | 300 | 300 | 2 | 0 | 602 |
| 14 | 0 | 301 | 300 | 2 | 0 | 603 |
| 15 | 0 | 300 | 300 | 2 | 0 | 602 |
| 16 | 45 | 300 | 300 | 31 | 15 | 691 |
| All | 408 | 2402 | 2700 | 45 | 84 | 5639 |

**Table 9** Latest regression snapshot.

| SUITE | STATUS | TEST/COV | SUMMARY |
|---|---|---|---|
| NVC code coverage | info | 99.8% | Per-DUT-file statement breakdown |
| OSVVM suite | PASS | 100% | 106 tests, 7 303 829 affirmations (module + top + AXI wrappers) |
| Golden model | PASS | 100% | 5555/5555 images byte-exact vs CharLS |
| Post-synth OSVVM | PASS | 100% | Control-plane stress on the gate-level netlist |
| Post-synth golden model | PASS | 100% | 167/167 8-bit images up to 0.05 MP byte-exact vs CharLS |
| HIL golden model | PASS | 100% | 5639/5639 images byte-exact vs CharLS on PYNQ-Z2 silicon |

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# Revision and contact

**Table 10** Revision history.

| VERSION | DATE | NOTES |
|---|---|---|
| 1.0 | 2026-06 | Initial release. |
| 1.1 | 2026-07 | Packaged IPs for Vivado. |
| 1.2 | 2026-07 | Isentropic branding; cores repackaged under the `isentropic` vendor. |
| 1.3 | 2026-09 | Frequency increased ≈15%, LUT reduction ≈16%, BRAM up 1 tile. |

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OpenJLS is developed and maintained by Isentropic. For commercial licensing, technical questions, or collaboration inquiries, contact **contact@isentropic.com.br**.

# References

[1] ITU-T T.87 | ISO/IEC 14495-1, *Lossless and near-lossless compression of continuous-tone still images — Baseline (JPEG-LS).*

[2] Y. M. Mert, *Key Architectural Optimizations for Hardware Efficient JPEG-LS Encoder*, IEEE, 2018.

[3] CharLS, JPEG-LS reference C++ library, https://github.com/team-charls/charls.
[4] open-logic, vendor-agnostic VHDL standard library, https://github.com/open-logic/open-logic.